

to an extent, but essentially destroys the whole notion of plug-and-play.

The Creative ZEN NEEON has a particularly sluggish interface. Button placements are okay, but needed more design thought. The Creative NOMAD Jukebox Zen Xtra was huge. This was a player that had a very primitive interface. It was bulkier, slower and did not even support the creation and use of folders. The only redeeming feature was the interface of the player that was easy to use. The buttons on the player however, can make do with a change in their positions. Considering the features, this player lacks a lot when compared to the other players in the comparison.

Performance

HDD-based portable audio players generally have to be used more carefully than flash-based players. This is because the HDD based players not only cost more, but are also more fragile due to moving parts. However, the newer generations of players that we tested were out to prove this wrong.

Audio Quality

The Samsung YH-J70 is at the forefront of this race. This baby has motion sensors to prevent accidental damage to the drive from jerks and falls.

To test this, we used this player when commuting on the roads of Mumbai, using public transport. Not once did it skip or restart—and some of the roads we traveled across are the worst in the country, especially after the terrible monsoon this year!

The Samsung gave us rock solid performance when it came to using it as a “portable” player. FM radio and audio recording quality was acceptable—though the FM reception quality could be improved upon.

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Earphone Buying Guide

The wrong earphones with the right player can cause a lot of heartburn. Earphones play a very important role in your whole digital music player experience. Therefore, to help you out, here is a small buying guide that will enhance your experience. Use these as generic guidelines when purchasing earphones or headphones. Prices may vary from region to region.

- ❑ Settle for the right fit. Some earphones have the tendency of slipping out of your ear. When buying an ear bud type of earphone, check if it fits your ear properly. Regular good quality earphones start retailing upwards of Rs300
- ❑ If you are not comfortable with an earphone, check out a headphone. The downside to this would be more consumption of battery, since the drivers are bigger on a headphone. Good quality headphones start retailing at approximately Rs1,000.
- ❑ Earphones can be either the regular or noise-canceling ones that plug right into the ear canal. Noise canceling earphones cost a bomb and are not recommended for long music sessions. However, the quality of these earphones is impeccable, since the audio waves directly hit the eardrum without any external interference leading to more clearer and noise free sound. The inherent drawback to these earphones is that low bitrate music files sound absolutely pathetic since they are encoded using lossy compression techniques.
- ❑ Headphones are also available in the noise-canceling flavor, and are extremely expensive. You can probably buy another player for the same price.
- ❑ For earphones, check if they have small ports at the back of the buds. These ports give more depth to the sound quality, especially to the bass. Such earphones can be expensive, but its money well spent. Good quality headphones also have small ports on the back of the ear cups.